

Improving future chances

The results from the Asian Championships will have more than just confidence-boosting benefits. "There are a lot of ranking points from this tournament. That will help me in the future because it will improve my seeding in important events," says Priya Ganghas (**below**), who won gold on her international debut in the women's 60kg category. "Even though I know I can take on any boxer, boxing is a game where one punch can change everything. It's better to meet the top boxers in the medal rounds rather than in the opening rounds."

"If we are competing against a good opponent, then obviously we have to be sharp all the time. At an early stage in a new environment, this isn't always easy because we aren't always habituated that fast. So if you face the best boxers in the semifinals

or finals, things become easier because you have time to get into your rhythm," says the 20-year-old.

While Nieva believes the team is on the right track, he says it is important not to get carried away. "I think we should see this as a great result, independent of how we do in the next competition. But of course, this year the main goals will be the Commonwealth Games and especially the Asian Games.

"If we don't achieve a similar result at the Asian Games, we will be disappointed. We know it will be tougher. Some of the opponents who lost will come back stronger, and some of us who won in Mongolia might get a tougher draw or have things not go perfectly," he says.

This is why, before the team left for a short break after the Asian Championships, Nieva reminded them that the job was not done.

"According to the selection criteria of the Boxing Federation of India (BFI), only the boxers who won gold or silver are assured of a place in the Asian Games and Commonwealth Games teams. Everyone else, including the bronze medallists — and even two-time world champion Nikhat Zareen and Olympic medallist Lovlina Borgohain — will have to go through another assessment in May," he says.

Even the boxers who have cemented their places know there is work to do. "From a technical and tactical point of view, there are still many things to work on. There were bouts that became very messy, with holding, wrestling and boxers falling to the floor. We were not always able to solve those situations or come back from that.

"We know we have to improve so that we don't have to depend on luck to win close bouts. Right now, a lot of boxers had their best days in the final. But there were also bouts where our boxers had a bad day, and that wasn't enough to win. We want to improve our baseline so that even on a bad day, it is still good enough to get the win," he says.

At least one boxer has the confidence that her bad day is still good enough at the continental level. Although she went on to beat two Olympic medallists, Preeti had a tough opening round in her first bout against former U-22 Asian champion Elina Bazarova of Kazakhstan.

"I actually lost the first round on all five scorecards, but fought back to win the next two rounds 5-0 and take the bout. When you lose the first round so convincingly, it's hard to come back, but I know now that I can change the bout situation anytime," she says.

But as she readies to return to the national camp, Preeti says she doesn't want to be in a similar situation in the tournaments to come. And while she has an Asian title, her hunger remains.

"I might have won gold at the Asian Championships, but right now the goal is to repeat my medal at the Asian Games. What I've done is not enough," she says.

